🚀 TPM Academy Kickoff

Half-Day Orientation • Pre-Week 1

Technical Product Manager Academy

🎯 Why This Half-Day Exists

An eight-week academy without a shared starting line tends to drift in week one. Today is the starting line.

- Name what a Technical Product Manager actually is — and isn't
- See the full arc of the eight weeks before Day 1 begins
- Form the **triads** you'll work with through Week 3's mini-capstone
- Agree on the ground rules: AI policy, notetaker policy, attendance, feedback
- Confirm everyone is technically ready for Monday

🕑 This Morning's Shape

Clock	Block	Outcome
09:00 – 09:30	Welcome & Introductions	Faces, names, why-you're-here
09:30 – 10:30	Block 1 — The TPM Role	Shared mental model of the job
10:30 – 10:45	**Break**	
10:45 – 11:45	Block 2 — Curriculum Tour + Triad Formation	Eight-week map; your triad
11:45 – 12:30	Logistics, Q&A, Week 1 launch	Ready to start Monday

🧪 Activity 1 — Two Truths and a TPM

Format: Full room → pairs • **20 min**

- Pair up with someone you've never worked with
- Each of you shares **three statements**: two true, one false — all about your product or engineering experience
- Partner guesses the false one and asks one follow-up question
- We'll surface the most surprising "truth" from each pair when we regroup

Goal: leave the icebreaker with one new face you can put a story to.

Block 1 — The TPM Role

What you're actually signing up to do

🧭 What is a Technical Product Manager?

A TPM owns the **outcome of a technically constrained product surface** — translating customer problems into engineering scope without losing either side of the translation.

- Lives at the intersection of **customer**, **system**, and **delivery**
- Owns a product requirements document (PRD) that engineering can build and customers will value
- Reasons about latency, data shape, dependencies, and trade-offs — not just features
- Negotiates priorities with stakeholders who hold conflicting truths

🔀 TPM vs PM vs EM

Product Manager

- What and why
- Customer evidence, market positioning
- Outcome ownership across the product
- Often less technical depth

Technical Product Manager

- What, why, **and feasible how**
- Customer evidence + system constraints
- Often owns API/platform/infra surfaces
- Speaks both languages fluently

Engineering Manager

- How and who
- People, delivery, technical execution quality
- Owns engineering capacity and team health

📚 The Five Sibling Artifacts

By Week 5 you'll have written each of these at least once:

Artifact	Question it answers	Owner of the truth
PRD — Product Requirements Document	What are we building and why?	TPM
TCD — Technical Concept Document	What is the high-level system shape?	TPM + Architect
TMD — Technical Modeling Document	What are the data and component models?	TPM + Tech Lead
SEP — Stakeholder Engagement Plan	Who is impacted and how do we engage them?	TPM
DP — Delivery Plan	How will we ship and measure?	TPM + EM

🧱 Where TPMs Tend to Fail

- **Pre-deciding the solution.** Walking in with the answer instead of the problem.
- **Misreading constraints.** Treating "we've never built that" as "we can't build that."
- **Hiding behind technical detail.** Using diagrams to dodge customer-value questions.
- **Hiding behind customer empathy.** Using personas to dodge technical accountability.
- **Owning every artifact alone.** The five sibling artifacts are *collaborative*, not solo writing exercises.

🧪 Activity 2 — "Where Have You Seen a TPM Win or Lose?"

Format: Quartets • **30 min**

- Each person writes a 60-second story: a real TPM (or PM doing TPM work) you saw *win* or *lose* a decision
- Read silently around the table — no narration
- The quartet picks **one** story and identifies which failure mode (or its inverse) was in play
- One quartet per readout: 90 seconds each

Deliverable: a tagged story per quartet, surfaced to the room.

☕ Break

15 minutes — be back at 10:45

Block 2 — Curriculum Tour + Triad Formation

Where this is going, and who you're going with

🗓️ The Eight-Week Map

Week 7 goes deep on Azure DevOps (ADO), our delivery toolchain.

Week	Theme	Capstone moment
1	Customer-Centric Foundations	—
2	Strategic Design & Metrics	—
3	Requirements Engineering	**Mini-capstone PRD + peer review**
4	Technical Architecture & Constraints	—
5	Technical Infrastructure & Modeling	—
6	Stakeholder Alignment & Negotiation	—
7	Agile Delivery & ADO Mastery	—
8	AI Spec Development & Capstone	**Real-world capstone + presentations**

🧭 The Capstone Arc

Week 3 Mini-Capstone

- Triad-built PRD
- Running case study: **FieldPulse** (HVAC dispatch SaaS)
- Peer review on Friday — every triad reads every other triad
- AI tools off — honor system

Week 8 Final Capstone

- Real product / problem you bring
- Full set of 5 sibling artifacts
- Friday: 12-minute presentation + Q&A
- AI tools on with validation discipline

🤖 The AI Policy in One Sentence

AI tools are **part of the curriculum, not a shortcut around it** — except Week 3, where they are explicitly off so the muscle of unaided requirements writing gets built.

- Weeks 1, 2, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8 — AI is in scope; validation discipline is required
- Week 3 — AI off in your editor, off in your browser, honor system
- Every AI-assisted artifact gets a **provenance note**: prompts used, what was kept, what was discarded

🧰 What You'll Use Day to Day

- **Markdown editor** with live preview (Obsidian / VS Code + MPE / Typora)
- **Two AI assistants** — Claude and ChatGPT are the most common; verify your access before Monday
- **Browser** for the academy repo, decks, and the SkillIQ assessments
- **Diagramming tool** — Miro / Lucidchart / Excalidraw / whiteboard
- **Azure DevOps** — Week 7 only; we'll confirm access before then

> Full setup instructions are in `participant-setup/TECH-SETUP.md`.

🧑‍🤝‍🧑 Triads — The Heart of the Cohort

- Three participants per triad — fixed through end of Week 3
- Every activity is run in triad unless otherwise marked
- Triads carry the Week 3 mini-capstone PRD together
- Composition rules: mix experience levels, mix domain backgrounds, no same-home-team pairs where possible
- Triads reshuffle for Weeks 4–8

🧪 Activity 3 — Triad Formation + First Commitment

Format: Self-organize → triads • **25 min**

- Stand. Find two people with at least one *different* dimension from you: experience level, domain, or home team
- Sit together. You are a triad through end of Week 3
- Write a **one-sentence triad commitment** — something like: "We will tell each other when our drafts are weak, before peer review tells us"
- Share triad names + commitments with the room — 30 seconds per triad

Deliverable: a named triad and a written commitment, on a single index card.

Logistics, Q&A, Week 1 Launch

The last 45 minutes

📍 Daily Rhythm Starting Monday

Block	Duration
Opening & objectives	0:15
Teaching Block 1 + Activity 1	1:15
Morning break	0:15
Teaching Block 2 + Activity 2	1:15
Lunch	1:00
Teaching Block 3 + Activity 3	1:15
Afternoon break	0:15
Teaching Block 4 + Activity 4 + Wrap	1:30

📣 Feedback & Channels

During the academy

- Daily anonymous pulse — one click, end of day
- Triad-internal: keep it direct, low-stakes
- Direct to instructor: any time, any channel

End of each week

- Friday 15-minute retrospective — what worked / what to adjust
- End-of-week pulse survey
- Adjustments visible by Monday

What to Bring Monday

- Laptop with markdown editor + browser + AI assistant access — all verified
- A real product you ship to today (internal or external) — Week 1 uses it as a discussion anchor
- Pre-work completed: PM Philosophies, Agile Methodologies, Prompt Engineering primer
- SkillIQ pre-assessments done — Product Management and Data Literacy
- Your triad commitment card

❓ Open Q&A

Common categories of questions to expect at this point:

- "What if my AI access doesn't work?"
- "What happens if I miss a day?"
- "Can our triad change if it's not working?"
- "How is performance evaluated?"
- "What artifacts do I keep after the academy?"

🚀 See You Monday at 09:00

Week 1, Day 1 — AI Fundamentals & Prompting for TPMs